Promoting Athletes Mental Health and Preventing Abuse

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, *Successful Coaching,* 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024), 52-57.

College as well as youth athletes have pressure to maintain classwork and grades as well as their practice and performance schedules. Overinvolvement in training, travel, and sport competition prevents the crucial recovery time and change of pace needed for optimal physical and mental health. Particularly for adolescent athletes, they have the additional stressors of identity development, anxiety over social status, and pressure to conform with peers. Globally, one in seven (14 percent) of 10- to 19-year-olds experiences a mental disorder, and suicide is the fourth leading cause of death among 15- to 19-year-olds (World Health Organization, 2021).

All of these stressors are compounded by the continuous public flow of information and time spent on social media. Research has shown a link between the amount of time spent on social media and higher levels of depression (Miller, 2020). By spending less time connecting with peers in person, kids lose out on the deeper, more personal friendships. Also, by spending more time on social media, adolescents are spending less time on activities that can build their competence, confidence, and sense of achievement. Finally, adolescents who spend time on their phones in the last hour prior to sleep get less sleep than their peers who don't use their phones before bed.

Mental Health Conditions That Athletes Face

The most common mental disorders in teens are depression, generalized anxiety, social anxiety disorder, and disordered eating. Physicians look at specific criteria to determine if a person has these mental disorders.

Depression

Depression usually appears as a depressed mood or lack of interest in typical hobbies and activities. In teens, depression can also contribute to a change in academic performance, disinterest in friends, and atypical irritability. Other symptoms include the following:

- Changes in sleep habits
- Changes in appetite
- Changes in concentration or ability to complete tasks
- Lower energy level and less motivation
- Feeling worthless, hopeless, or helpless

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- Thoughts of suicide

Occasional episodes of irritability or depressed mood is not atypical. However, if such feelings persist for weeks or if other unusual symptoms appear, then the athlete should seek counseling with a mental health professional.

Generalized Anxiety

Generalized anxiety disorder (GAD) includes excessive worry and fear that seems to have no cause, or to be more intense than seems appropriate for the situation. These worries can be about future events, physical appearance, social acceptance, failure to meet expectations, past behaviors, and school performance. All of us experience anxiety at times, which is normal. GAD involves anxiety that doesn't go away and often interferes with normal activities. Other symptoms of GAD include the following:

- Feeling restless, wound up, or on edge
- Becoming fatigued easily
- Struggling with sleep
- Having near-constant thoughts and fears about safety of self and loved ones

Social Anxiety Disorder

Social anxiety disorder (SAD) affects one out of three adolescents between 13 and 18 years old. It is the most common anxiety disorder, and it is characterized by a pervasive fear of social interactions or situations where embarrassment might occur. Although it's common to feel some anxiety in new social situations, SAD prevents people from developing normal relationships. Symptoms include the following:

- Overwhelming self-consciousness
- Fear of judgment
- Worry about upcoming social situations, even weeks in advance
- Avoidance of social interactions
- Nausea, blushing, sweating in everyday social situations

Disordered Eating

Eating disorders have increased at an alarming rate over the past few decades, as pressure to perform and to look thin and fit while performing has increased in sport. Anorexia nervosa is an eating disorder in which people restrict eating (virtually starving themselves) because they view themselves as overweight even if they are at least 15 percent below the expected weight for their age and height. Bulimia nervosa is an eating disorder in which people, usually in the normal weight range, repeat a cycle of overeating and then purging, fasting, or exercising excessively.

All athletes can develop disordered eating patterns, but they occur much more frequently in female athletes. Rates of eating disorders are higher for female athletes in

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appearance-oriented (gymnastics, figure skating) and lean (swimming, diving, track and field) sports as compared to other sports. Sometimes, personality characteristics such as perfectionism, high achievement orientation, and concern with body image are associated with disordered eating. The following behaviors might indicate an eating disorder in an athlete:

- Eating extremes, from binging to undereating
- Changes in mood and personality
- Socially isolating from others, especially during meals
- Obsession with body or weight

Dealing With Athletes' Mental Health Issues: Strategies for Coaches

Coaches should have an awareness and a basic understanding of typical mental health issues in sport so they can both prevent their occurrences as much as possible and support athletes when mental health issues arise. The mental health issues described in this section are clinical disorders, which require intervention with a clinical mental health professional. These are not situations where coaches should attempt to intervene or help the athlete "work through it" or "get better." Here are some suggestions:

- Avoid disparaging or joking remarks about athletes' bodies, weight, or fit of uniform, as these types of comments contribute to body image issues and disordered eating.
- Jokes or insensitive questions about mental health ("What's wrong with you? You're acting weird.") are inappropriate. Mental disorders aren't weird—they are more common than we realize, and they are treatable. In the United States, one in four people experience a mental health condition in any given year (Johns Hopkins Medicine, 2022).
- Normalize conversations around mental health by showing your emotional vulnerability and encouraging athletes to be open about emotions, particularly during difficult times. Football coach Dabo Swinney encourages open communication in his team with a culture of "no matter what, it's okay, and we're here to help" (Meister & Lavanchy, 2021).
- Spend time talking with your athletes about things other than their performance. When asking "How are you?" you should mean it and follow up if needed to seek an honest answer. Check in with athletes and ask what they do to recharge and relax from their training and other responsibilities.
- Your sport organization or administrator should have a list of mental health professionals in your organization or surrounding community so you can refer athletes and their parents or guardians to these people. They could include counseling and clinical psychologists, school counselors, and clinical social workers.

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- When you observe symptoms of a mental health disorder, it's important to act because these are serious problems that can have dire consequences. Plan to approach athletes thoughtfully and with care. Ask to speak with them in private and avoid using direct terms like *eating disorder* or *mental illness.* Describe their behavior instead of evaluating or accusing them. You might say, "I'm worried about you. You seem distracted and down, and it doesn't seem like you're having fun. I just want to make sure you're okay. Is there anything wrong, and can I do anything to help?"
- People commonly feel shame and embarrassment when help is offered, so you can expect some athletes to say that they are fine and to reject your help. Gently persist by talking with the person again, and offer different types of assistance (e.g., "Would it help if I met with you and your parents [or guardians]?" or "Would you be comfortable meeting with the school counselor?").

To summarize: We as coaches need to focus as much on our athletes' mental health as we do on their physical health and performance. It's easy to get caught up in the performance success of athletes, and to assume that this success implies mental health success. But it does not. We can make a difference in young athletes' lives, even beyond teaching skills and life lessons, by ensuring that they feel mentally safe in their sport.

Preventing Sexual Harassment and Abuse in Youth Sport

Swimming coach Andy King was discovered to have sexually abused more than a dozen female swimmers over a 30-year period and was caught only when a 14-year-old victim spoke up about the abuse. USA Swimming banned the coach for life, and King is now serving a 40-year prison sentence. USA Swimming has banned at least 36 swim coaches for alleged sexual misconduct.

The USA Gymnastics sex abuse scandal is considered the largest sexual abuse scandal in sports history. It only emerged in 2016 when an *Indianapolis Star* (newspaper) investigation found that executives at USA Gymnastics failed to alert authorities to many allegations of sexual abuse by coaches. This led to gymnasts coming forward to reveal decades of sexual abuse by USA Gymnastics team doctor Larry Nassar. Hundreds of women disclosed Nassar's molestation of them, which resulted in Nassar's conviction and sentencing to more than 100 years in prison. Nassar is only the tip of the iceberg, part of a culture in which coaches abuse the power and trust that athletes and parents provide them to engage in what almost appears to be sport-sanctioned pedophilia.

Policies and Guidelines Related to Sexual Abuse and Harassment by Coaches

Sexual abuse refers to any sexual activity for which consent is not or cannot be given, which typically involves manipulation and entrapment of athletes (International

Olympic Committee, 2008). Sexual harassment is sexualized verbal or nonverbal behavior that is unwanted or coercively imposed. Sexual harassment can be anything that creates an uncomfortable environment, and doesn't only involve sexual advances but also includes offensive sexual comments or jokes, discussions about sex or your own sex life, and the display of sexually oriented photos or cartoons. Athletes often wear revealing uniforms, and coaches should refrain from commenting on athletes' bodies or glancing up and down their bodies in an appraising way. Coaches should avoid any behavior, verbal or nonverbal, that would make their athletes uncomfortable in any sexual way.

Sexual abuse and harassment represent a misuse of power and trust granted to an adult, with male coaches more often reported than females. Youth athletes are frequent targets because they trust that their coaches are caring adults committed to their well-being. (Sexual harassment may also occur with assistant coaches, athletic trainers, and other people associated with sport programs. This type of sexual harassment is perpetrated against other adults.)

Due to the multitude of sexual abuse cases involving coaches that have become public, many sport organizations have developed policies and mandatory athlete protection training for adults involved in the program, including coaches. Coaches should be familiar with the policies of their specific sport organization with regard to sexual harassment and abuse. The U.S. Center for SafeSport provides a course that many organizations have adopted. USA Swimming adopted SafeSport's Minor Athlete Abuse Prevention Policy and requires training for all coaches, meet directors, officials, chaperones, and adult athletes. Following are some of the rules of that program that apply to coaches (as well as other applicable adults):

- Meetings between a minor athlete and coach should occur in the presence of another adult. If a one-on-one meeting is necessary, the door of the room should remain open.
- All electronic communication from coaches to minor athletes should be professional in nature. Parents and guardians may request that their minor athlete not be contacted through any form of electronic communication by the coach.
- Coaches should not maintain private social media connections with or accept new personal page requests on social media platforms from minor athletes.
- Coaches should not ride in a car alone with a minor athlete.
- Coaches may not share overnight lodging with an athlete, and if doing team room checks in a hotel, should be accompanied by another adult.
- At no time should a coach be alone with a minor athlete in a locker room.

A policy on sexual harassment from the Women's Sports Foundation is provided here as another example of an organizational approach to educating coaches. This policy, as well

as the NCAA policy to prevent inappropriate relationships between athletes and coaches (Brake & Nelson, 2012), clarifies that it is unethical for coaches to engage in a consensual or sexual relationship with athletes, even if they have reached adult status. This involves the issue of dual relationships, in which coaches who have an established professional relationship with an athlete cannot ethically engage in a simultaneous personal relationship with that athlete. The problem lies in the power that the coach holds in relation to the athlete, and thus the athlete's inability to freely make a choice about the relationship. Due to this power differential, any amorous or sexual relationships between coaches and athletes constitute sexual abuse.

Women's Sports Foundation Policy on Sexual Harassment and Sexual Relationships Between Coaches and Athletes

1. Sexual harassment and sexual relationships between coaches and athletes subvert the mission of sports organizations and educational institutions to provide leadership and resources for the purpose of improving the physical, mental, and emotional well-being of all [athletes] through sport and fitness participation.
2. Sexual harassment has debilitating consequences both for its victims and for the society as a whole. In the context of athletic programs, it lowers the self-esteem and limits the ability of [athletes] to develop their full potential in sports and fitness activities. It impairs the future capacity of its victims to experience full athletic participation and to pursue employment and leadership roles in athletics. This, in turn, deprives the society as a whole of the contributions of these [athletes] and damages a genuine appreciation of [athletes'] achievements and contributions.
3. Consensual and/or sexual relationships between coaches and athletes undermine the professionalism of coaches, taint the atmosphere of mutual trust and respect between coach and athlete, and hinder the fulfillment of the overall educational mission of athletics. The WSF views it as unethical if coaches engage in consensual and/or sexual relations with athletes under their supervision, even when both parties have apparently consented to the relationship.
4. In order to effectively deal with cases of sexual harassment in athletics, as well as to prevent future abuse of [athletes] by coaches, the WSF encourages officers of sports governance bodies, athletic directors, and school administrators to formulate policy guidelines and procedures that include periodic training and distribution of the policy, subsequent evaluation of its effectiveness, and effective responses to sexual harassment in a timely manner.

Adapted from "Sexual Harassment and Sexual Relationships Between Coaches, Other Athletic Personnel and Athletes: The Foundation Position," Women's Sports Foundation, last modified August 30, 2016, www.womenssportsfoundation.org/advocacy/sexual-harassment-sexual-relationships-coaches-athletic-personnel-athletes/.

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Coaching Recommendations to Avoid and Prevent Sexual Harassment

In addition to refraining from obvious unethical and illegal sexual harassment and abuse of their athletes, coaches must also be acutely aware of behaviors and practices that may be construed as harassment (without their conscious intent to do so). In today's society, it is imperative that coaches follow minor athlete protection policies, even if a policy seems unneeded or absurd to them. Your focus should include protecting your athletes, as well as yourself as a coach in a position of power and control over others.



All of your interactions with athletes of any gender should be free of sexual innuendo and anything that would make the athlete uncomfortable.

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1. Keep all electronic communication between you and your athletes professional and used for team information dissemination as opposed to personal conversation. If you need to send a personal phone text to an athlete (e.g., to check on an injury), include the athlete's parent or guardian on the text. If you use team communication apps such as GroupMe or BAND, follow the rule of keeping your electronic communication with team members professional.
2. Do not respond to your athletes' social media posts, and ask your athletes to remove you from their lists. Due to the extreme popularity of social media with young people today, it is likely that your athletes will include you on social media posts. Explain to your athletes at the beginning of the training season why you wish to remain separate from their social media posts. To protect yourself and your athletes, draw a firm line of not engaging in any nonprofessional (i.e., unrelated to team activities) electronic communication with your athletes.

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3. Whenever possible, have another person present when interacting with your athletes. If you're working individually with an athlete out of the normal group training session, make sure other people are present or at least in the area (e.g., across the gym or field).
4. Avoid remarks, jokes, or innuendo about an athlete's body, appearance, sex, sexual orientation, sexual activities, or sexual favors. Avoid inappropriate or derogatory sexual language as well as obscene or suggestive gestures.
5. Touch your athletes in socially responsible ways. Sometimes you may need to touch athletes to guide their movements to learn a skill or treat an injury. Do so only with others present. A pat on the buttocks by a male coach to a male player is a historically common coaching reinforcement, but it is not appropriate with a female player and probably is outdated and inappropriate all-around today. A high-five or pat on the back is more appropriate. If you accidentally touch an inappropriate body part during your coaching, don't ignore or joke about it. Excuse yourself and make it clear that the action was unintentional.
6. You have a duty as a coach to prevent sexual harassment and abuse by your athletes or assistants. This can occur in mixed-sex as well as same-sex teams. When appointing assistant coaches who you don't know, remember that sexual predators seek out venues where they have easy access to kids. Revelations about sexual abuse of children by Boy Scout leaders, Roman Catholic priests, and sport team physicians support this point.
7. Discuss the issue of sexual harassment at a preseason meeting with athletes, parents, and guardians. Ask them to notify you immediately if they experience or perceive any action on your part as harassment. In addition, ask them to notify you if they experience or perceive sexual harassment by another athlete or anyone associated with the team.
8. If you are accused of sexual harassment, listen carefully to the complaint and don't try to avoid, cover up, or make light of the accusation. Instead, respect the other person's viewpoint, identify the offending behavior, and learn from the experience.

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